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The Queen's Gambit Declined for Black

Orthodox, Ragozin, Vienna, Tarrasch, structures, and active equality

COURSE BOOK

21 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

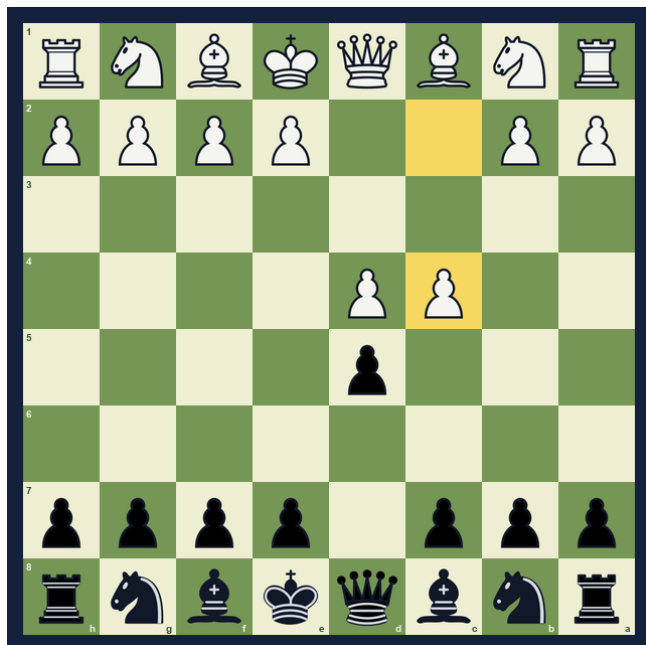
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
01 - Foundations	10
03 - Queen's Gambit Declined	6
04 - Ragozin and Vienna	3
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01. The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Name Black's pawn support or capture.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

01. Decision Framework

The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.
PIECE JOB	Black takes on c4 and gives White time and central space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.

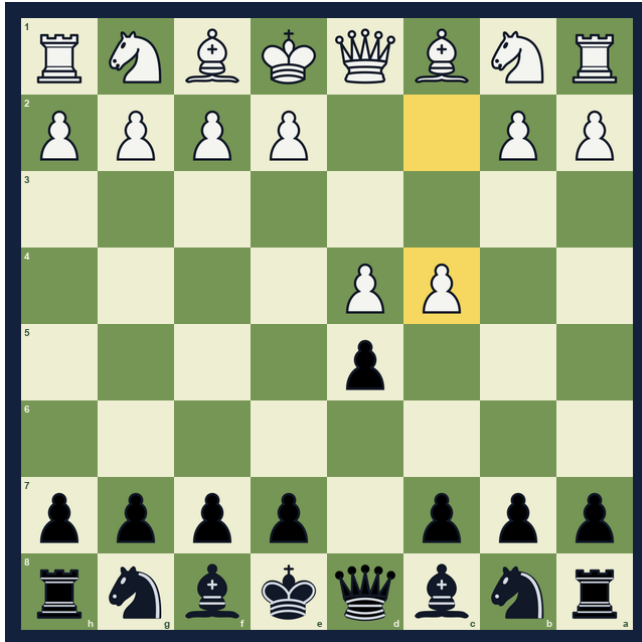
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

02. Why the c-Pawn Is Offered



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Did Black protect, capture, or ignore c4?

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

02. Decision Framework

Why the c-Pawn Is Offered

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.
PIECE JOB	Black usually spends time trying to keep an extra wing pawn. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.

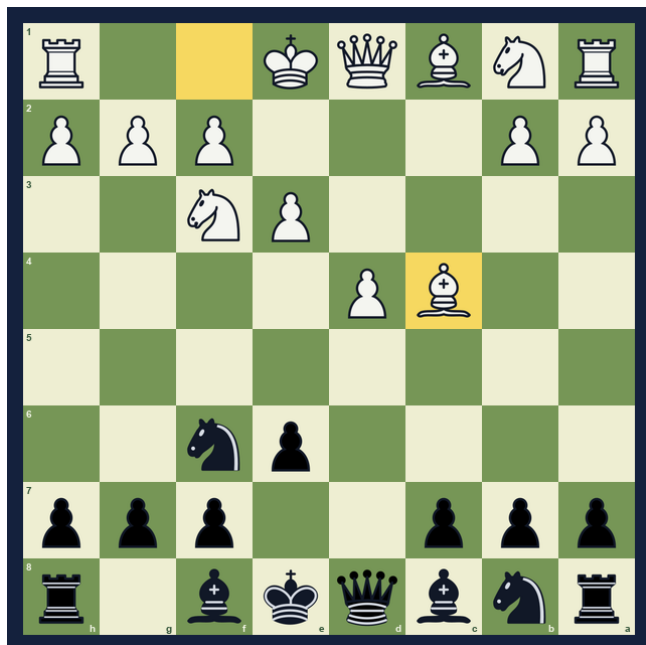
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

03. How White Recovers the c4 Pawn



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Nf3 and e3 before chasing material.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

03. Decision Framework

How White Recovers the c4 Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.
PIECE JOB	e3 opens the bishop without weakening the center. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

04. Do Not Rush the Central Tension



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Make useful moves while the tension remains.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

04. Decision Framework

Do Not Rush the Central Tension

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.
PIECE JOB	Black's setup reveals which exchange is most useful. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.

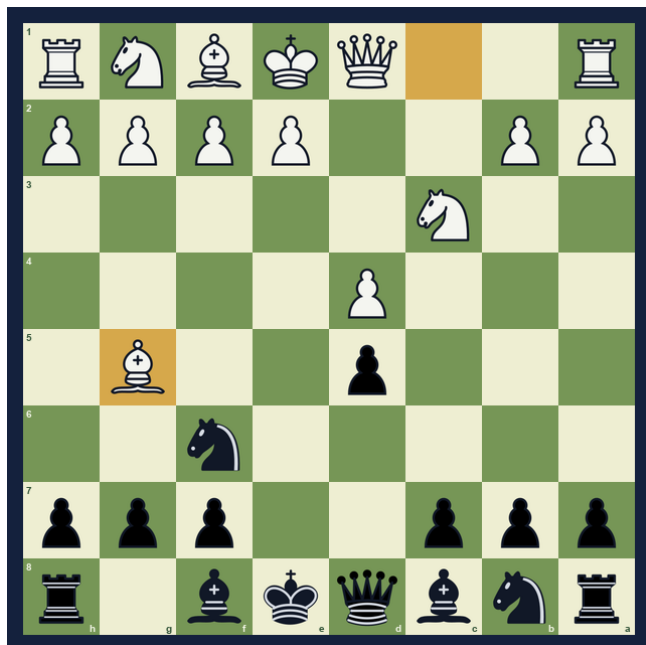
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

05. When White Plays cxd5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Choose cxd5 when you want a stable plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

05. Decision Framework

When White Plays cxd5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.
PIECE JOB	Bg5 develops before e3 closes the diagonal. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

06. When White Plays dxc5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Develop enough pieces before changing the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

06. Decision Framework

When White Plays dxc5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.
PIECE JOB	b4 attacks the bishop while gaining queenside space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.

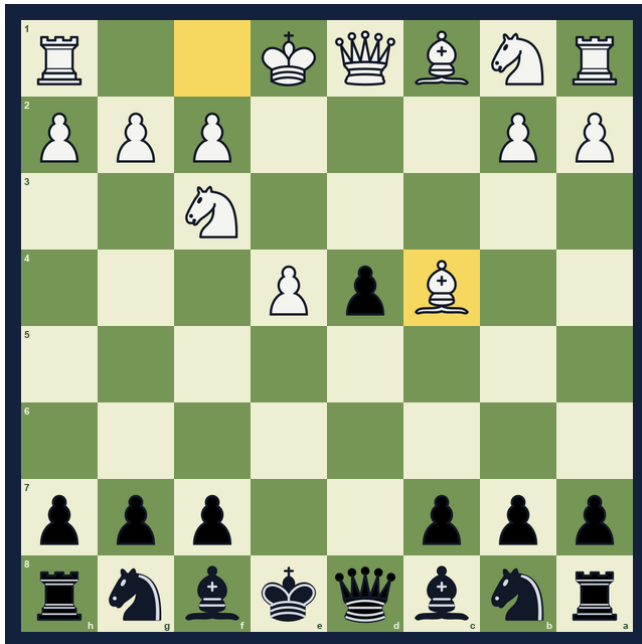
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

07. The e4 Break Is White's Dream



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use e4 when Black cannot undermine it immediately.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

07. Decision Framework

The e4 Break Is White's Dream

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.
PIECE JOB	Nf3 and Bxc4 bring pieces out with tempo. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

08. The Minority Attack Roadmap



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Complete the piece setup first.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

08. Decision Framework

The Minority Attack Roadmap

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.
PIECE JOB	b5 challenges c6 and forces a structural decision. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

09. Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Identify whether Black has committed to d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

09. Decision Framework

Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.
PIECE JOB	After d5 and Nc3, the position becomes a QGD. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.

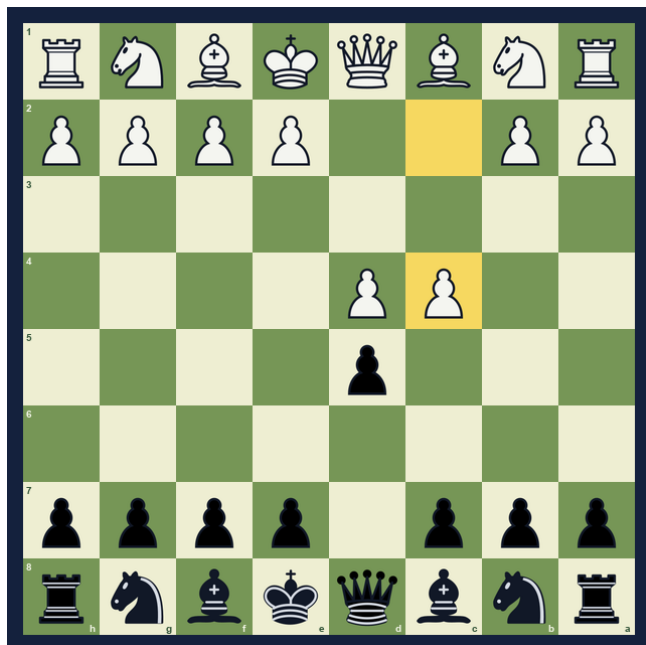
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

10. How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.

PRIMARY PLAN

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Study one short lesson.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

10. Decision Framework

How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.
PIECE JOB	Explain why each White move helps the structure. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

11. QGD Exchange with Nf3



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

11. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

12. QGD Orthodox Main Line



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use pieces to keep Black's center tied down.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

12. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

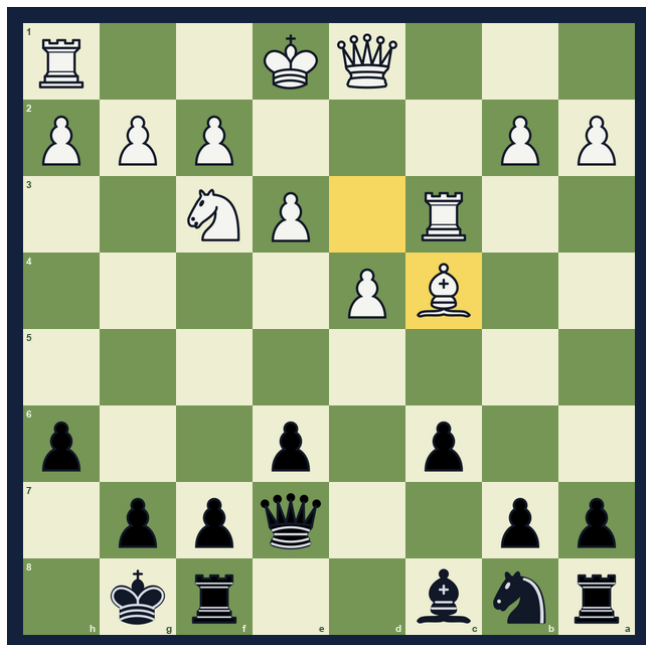
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

13. QGD Lasker Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use the c-file and active bishops after exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

13. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
PIECE JOB	After Black's ...Ne4 exchanges, White's remaining pieces must occupy the open c- and e-files quickly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not cooperate with every simplification.
TRADE FILTER	Accept simplification when it leaves a queenside weakness or superior minor piece; otherwise preserve tension and space.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Rebuild pressure after the forced trades by centralizing rooks and improving the least active remaining piece. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not cooperate with every simplification.

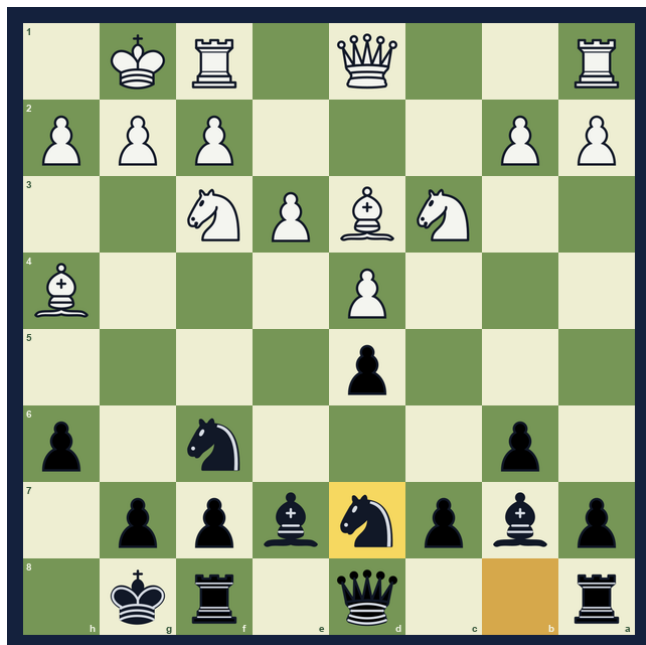
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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

14. QGD Tartakower Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

...b6-Bb7: Black activates the previously bad bishop.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Pressure c7 and queenside entry squares.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

14. Decision Framework

QGD Tartakower Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.
PIECE JOB	White should pressure the queenside dark squares while preventing Black's b7-bishop from becoming completely free.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active bishop when that leaves exploitable light-square or queenside weaknesses, not merely to simplify.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Convert small space and structural edges by restricting the hanging pawns, then attacking them after their activity fades. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

15. Cambridge Springs Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Qa5: Black creates the Cambridge Springs pin and pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Nd2 and Qc2 to remove tactical pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Nbd7 5. e3 c6 6. Nf3 Qa5 7. Nd2 Bb4 8. Qc2 O-O 9. Be2 dxc4 10. Bxf6 Nxf6 11. Nxc4 Qc7 12. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

15. Decision Framework

Cambridge Springs Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.
PIECE JOB	Nd2, Qc2 and Be2 form a safety net that unpins the queenside before White tries to recover c4.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.
TRADE FILTER	Bxf6 is useful when it removes a tactical defender and permits Nxc4; the order matters more than the desire to keep bishops.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Neutralize the pins, recover the pawn with a developed piece, castle, and only then look for an advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

16. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.

PRIMARY PLAN

...c5: Black challenges d4 and seeks equality.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Complete Qc2, Rd1, and a3 with pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

16. Decision Framework

QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop controls e5 and helps White develop pressure without committing to the traditional Bg5 pin.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the f4-bishop only when the remaining structure or open file compensates for losing its central influence.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use Qc2, Rd1 and a3 to finish development, then turn control of e5 and the d-file into concrete pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

17. Ragozin Exchange Structure



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

17. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

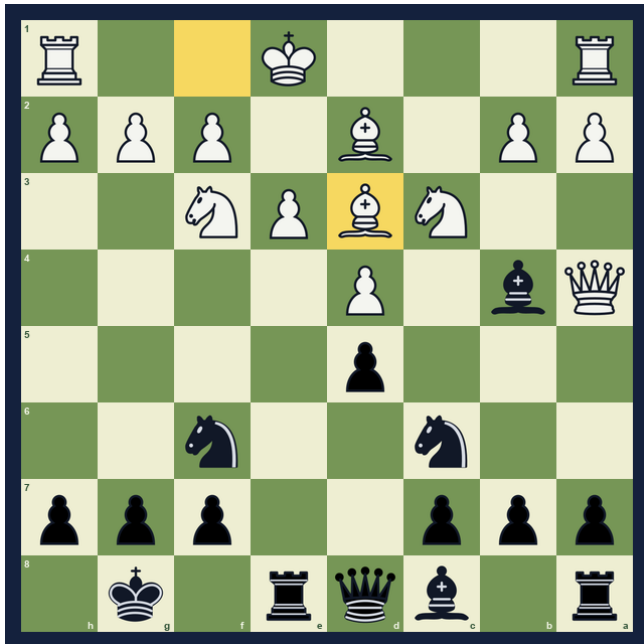
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

18. Ragozin Qa4 Check



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Nc6: Black blocks the check and increases d4 pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bd2 and a3 ideas to improve while challenging Bb4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

18. Decision Framework

Ragozin Qa4 Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ gains information, while Bd2 and Bd3 complete development without letting the queen become the center of attention.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.
TRADE FILTER	A bishop trade on b4 is useful when it improves development or pawn structure; avoid chasing the bishop for its own sake.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the information gained by Qa4+ to choose the structure, then centralize the rooks and stop moving the queen repeatedly. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

19. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Bb4: Black pins c3 and attacks the center indirectly.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Develop rapidly behind the e5 and d4 center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

19. Decision Framework

Vienna Variation Central Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns give space, but Bd2 and rapid castling are the pieces' urgent jobs while the c3-knight is pinned.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.
TRADE FILTER	Do not trade the pieces defending e4 and d4 without calculating the center; structural damage can be acceptable if open lines remain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Unpin, recover c4 when safe, open lines, and secure the king before trying to exploit the space advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.

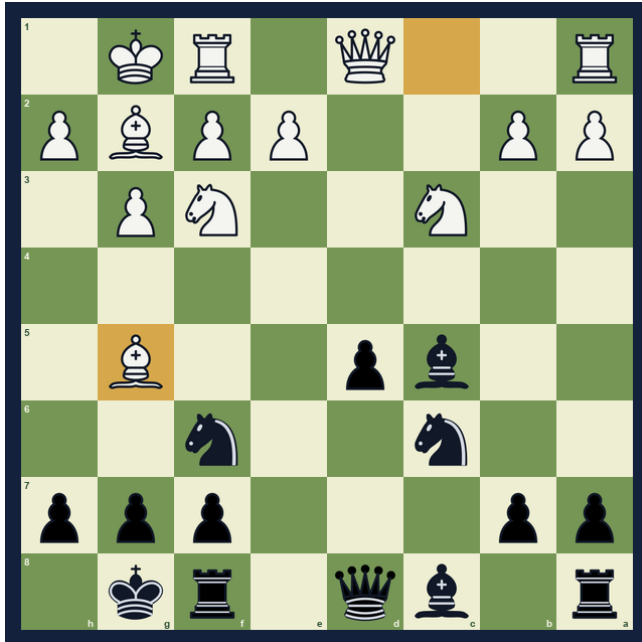
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

20. Tarrasch Defense Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Nc6: Black supports d4 and active development.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Control d4 and place a piece in front of the isolated pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

20. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Defense Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.
PIECE JOB	White's g2-bishop pressures d5 while the other pieces blockade and attack Black's isolated queen's pawn.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade active Black pieces-especially those supporting d4 or e4-but keep enough pieces to attack the isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Blockade first, exchange attackers second, then convert the fixed d-pawn or superior minor-piece endgame. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.

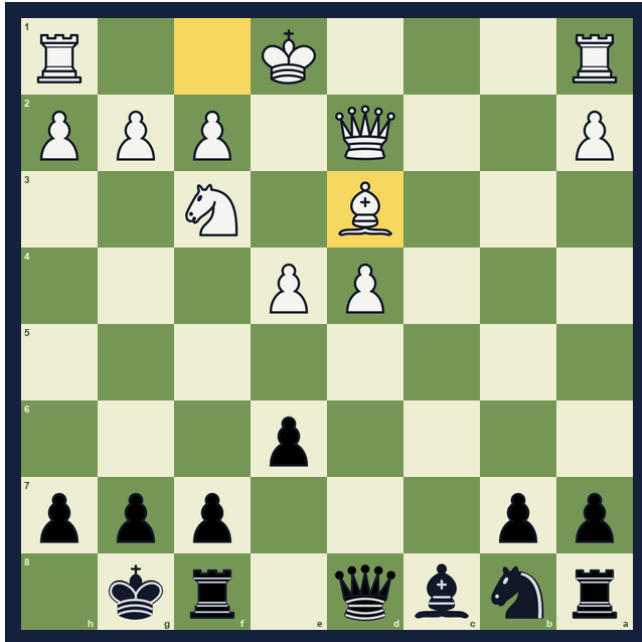
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

21. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

PRIMARY PLAN

...Nxc3: Black damages White's pawn shape but gives the bishop pair.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Use Bd3, O-O, and rooks to support e4 and d4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

21. Decision Framework

Semi-Tarrasch Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawn duo needs quick piece support because Black has open lines and easy development.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not advance e5 before completing development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid mass exchanges that turn the central majority into a fixed target; trade when the pawn center can advance afterward.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, use the space to restrict Black, and transform the center before it becomes overextended. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not advance e5 before completing development.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.